programme was too short a period for any student to be awarded a degree. It was another matter that there was no time frame for degrees—only that you had to meet the academic criteria, which I had by putting in longer hours.

'Why don't you do the project a few more times and make it terribly attractive?' he said.

I said 'yes'.

According to Prof Srignano's calculations, that should keep me on the campus—and the project—for a good one-and-a-half months, so that there is a 'respectable' year into my graduation. I disappointed him by doing the extra repeats in ten days. Without the assistance of technicians Lawrence and Ken, who were now active participants in my project and passion, this would have been impossible.

Now I had completed the extra work, well within eleven months. Prof. Harrje now had another plan to keep me in the degree project for a few more months: I should visit a few reputed space science institutions in the US. I would get an inclination of what Prof. Harrje, as a willing patriot of the American system of grabbing Indian scientists, only later, but I readily agreed. After all, an Indian space scientist getting access to Goddard Space Flight Centre, Aerojet General Corporation, Bell Aerospace, Hercules Powder Company, Thiokol Chemical Corporation, Boeing and half-a-dozen more companies was rare. I decided to play along—and win.

The benefits of the fleeting yet unrestricted visits I considered big. At the end of it all—which was another month—I had a fair idea about developing both solid and liquid propulsion systems. I had also made acquaintances who would later prove useful for ISRO. One of them was a gentleman called Delwell, who was then with Boeing. Later, after he joined Airbus Industries as a technical director, he approached me with a barter: I should influence the India government to buy Air Bus aircraft; in return he would give me the total stage engineering of the Viking engine.

My faint suspicions about some people trying to delay my stay in the US took the shape of clarity soon when I got a call from a person called Eugene Scott of NASA.

'We will be happy if you stay back in the US,' she said.